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Disclosure: *Former-employer disclosure: NiCE is a former employer of the author. All NiCE research here is public-source only; no LinkedIn queries or visits were made for NiCE or Cognyte. The parent report is published at <https://productbeacon.agency/research/state-of-wfo-2026/>.*

This week's main developments

- Salesforce completed its \$3.6 billion acquisition of Fin. It now controls both Fin and Agentforce pricing.
- Five9 reports growing human-seat numbers while expecting AI to reduce seats over time. Its AI revenue exceeds \$150 million annualised, according to management.
- California's three workplace-AI bills await the Governor. They become law unless the Governor vetoes them by 30 September.
- LanguageLine workers report scheduling problems after a NiCE software rollout. LanguageLine says operations are back to normal.
- Observe.AI launched AI coaching tools that require supervisor approval. ISG's WEM rankings favour established platforms over independent specialists.

Salesforce buys Fin

- The deal closed one quarter earlier than Salesforce's June guidance. Fin, formerly Intercom, joins Salesforce AI Labs; Eoghan McCabe remains chief executive.
- Salesforce reports more than 30,000 Fin customer companies and a 76% average resolution rate across chat, email, WhatsApp, SMS, voice and Slack.
- Fin lists \$0.99 per outcome. Agentforce lists \$2 per conversation and \$2 per Help Agent resolution.
- Fin still supports rival help desks, including HubSpot, Freshworks, Zoho, Front, Dixa, Sprinklr and Gorgias.
- Salesforce positions Fin for quick deployment across help desks and Agentforce for more customisable enterprise use.
- **Watch:** whether Salesforce keeps those prices separate, combines them or charges through both products.

Listen Labs talks remain unconfirmed

- Business Insider reports Salesforce acquisition talks with Listen Labs at around \$2 billion. Neither company commented; no agreement had been reached.
- TechCrunch reports that Listen Labs abandoned a signed \$125 million funding term sheet at a \$1.5 billion valuation to pursue the talks.
- Listen Labs was last valued at \$500 million in January. Its customer-research platform is adjacent to contact-centre analytics.

Five9 expects AI to change the seat model

- CEO Amit Mathradas says human-agent numbers are growing in line with 7% contact-centre subscription revenue growth.
- He expects fewer human seats over time: “Over time, will there be compression in human seats? Sure.”
- At Goldman Sachs’ conference, CFO Bryan Lee reported AI revenue above \$150 million annualised and AI Agent gross margin “in the high 70s.”
- Lee expects AI to improve Five9’s overall gross margin.
- Management argues that spending can shift from human seats to AI within the contact-centre budget, citing \$25 billion markets for each.
- Customers commit to a dollar amount, then move between agreed numbers of human seats and AI agents within set bands.
- Five9 charges for AI in blocks of committed minutes, with higher rates for overage.
- **Implication:** workforce plans increasingly need to account for both people and AI usage. Growing human seats show that displacement is not yet straightforward.

Five9 describes shared routing and quality tools

- Mathradas says Five9 scores human and AI agents on the same competencies, then routes work to a named agent rather than a queue.
- He says its quality-management platform measures both human and AI interactions.
- Five9 added detail to its previously announced \$100 million Fortune 100 contract: a five-year commitment with expansion, replacing monthly arrangements.
- Management describes an on-premises-to-cloud migration with hands-on implementation from Google.

AI pricing uses several charging models

Vendor	Published or announced model
Fin	\$0.99 per outcome; \$9.99 per qualification; \$19 monthly help-desk seats; \$35 monthly Copilot users.
Agentforce	\$2 per conversation or Help Agent resolution; employee-facing products also use per-user pricing.
Five9	Committed AI minutes, with higher-priced overage, according to management.
Microsoft	Human seats plus Copilot Credits for autonomous agents.

Vendor	Published or announced model
Lorikeet	Platform fee plus resolution charges; no seat pricing.
Zendesk	Plans usage-based voice-translation pricing; amount not set.

- Sierra, Decagon and Parloa do not publish list prices on their own sites.
- **Implication:** buying AI now requires comparing the charging unit as well as the rate. Outcomes, minutes and credits measure different things.

Lorikeet charges for resolutions without seats

- Chat, email and SMS resolutions cost \$0.99; voice resolutions cost \$1.50. Triage and automated quality assurance each cost \$0.30.
- Platform fees are \$2,100 monthly below 5,000 tickets and \$5,100 monthly up to 20,000 tickets.
- Lorikeet says customers do not pay for tickets they are unhappy with.
- **Implication:** outcome pricing is already available, but services and platform fees still matter when comparing the total cost.

Microsoft includes assistance, then charges for autonomous work

- Dynamics 365 Contact Center lists at \$110 per user per month, paid yearly. Digital and Voice editions list at \$95.
- The seat includes Copilot, case and conversation summaries, knowledge Q&A, email assistance and live translation.
- Recording, transcription, inbound voice routing and performance analytics are also included among the listed features.
- Customer Intent Agent, Customer Knowledge Management Agent and Quality Evaluation Agent each require separately sold Copilot Credits.
- **Implication:** the listed tools that help a person are included in the seat. Agents that perform work independently incur separate charges.

Zendesk's translation pricing takes a different approach

- Zendesk announced bidirectional live translation inside its agent desktop, enabled by queue.
- Closed early access starts in October; general availability is planned for Q1 2027.
- Zendesk says it will charge by usage, with prices set after learning from early access.
- This is human-assist software with a separate usage charge, qualifying the pattern seen at Microsoft.

Customers report less work after calls

These are customer and vendor reports. The Genesys conference examples were reported this week after presentations on 2–3 September.

- **DNB:** reports 50% less after-call work with Genesys Copilot. It migrated 3,400 users from on-premises systems in twelve months.
- **Rabobank:** reports 20,000 employees using Genesys copilots and an end to manual interaction summaries. Genesys calls this its largest copilot deployment.
- **Auto Club Enterprises:** moved 10,000 agents to Genesys Cloud in two months and says routine work such as summaries can be automated.
- **Child Bereavement UK:** reports roughly 24 hours saved across 15 agents during July and August, varying with call length and mix.
- The charity requires practitioners to edit AI summaries before they enter customer records. Its aim is shorter queues while preserving human judgement.

NiCE connects human and AI routing at AOK PLUS

- NiCE reports AOK PLUS live on Cognigy and CXone, following the earlier HM Revenue and Customs deployment.
- The insurer covers more than 3.4 million members in Saxony and Thuringia and handles more than 5 million interactions annually, according to NiCE.
- NiCE reports a call-acceptance rate above 95% and more than 1,400 telephone numbers migrated with zero downtime.
- The deployment connects AI interactions with 2,400 employees and 120 routing skills in NiCE's European sovereign cloud.
- **Implication:** human and AI agents increasingly share routing, skills and quality-management systems.

LanguageLine workers report scheduling problems

- LanguageLine interpreters told Capital & Main that workloads and schedules worsened after their employer deployed NiCE workforce-management software in 2025.
- Workers described breaks moving unexpectedly, shifts cut at short notice and as little as 15 seconds between calls at busy hours. Working conditions are cited in a unionisation campaign.
- LanguageLine says the rollout coincided with industry pressure, it has adjusted operations, and things are “back to normal.” It attributes most schedule complaints to federal budget pressure.
- The account concerns the employer's deployment and scheduling decisions. No NiCE response appears in the article; it does not establish vendor fault.

Observe.AI links quality scores to coaching

- Performance Agents analyses conversations, identifies coaching needs, gathers supporting evidence, prepares plans and measures subsequent performance.
- Supervisors review, edit and approve every coaching plan before it reaches a worker. The product does not make autonomous employment or performance decisions.
- Observe.AI says preparation can take less than five minutes in applicable workflows. It named no customer, price or availability date.
- Teams can configure the software around their terminology, quality forms and coaching methods, including GROW, SMART and IDEA.
- **Implication:** vendors increasingly compete on improving performance after scoring a conversation. Independent proof of coaching outcomes remains limited.

Broad interaction scoring is becoming standard

- Verint, NiCE, Level AI, Observe.AI, 3CLogic and Zendesk advertise scoring all interactions. Verint qualifies its wording as “up to” 100%.
- Observe.AI's preparation claim and Verint's claimed \$28 million annual coaching value illustrate the focus on outcomes; both are vendor-supplied figures.

ISG ranks established platforms ahead of specialists

- ISG's eight contact-centre Buyers Guides assess 44 providers. NiCE, Verint and Genesys lead both the Contact Centers and WEM guides, in that order.
- NiCE ranks first overall in seven of the eight guides.
- Cresta and Sierra appear on no Exemplary or Innovative list across those guides. Neither is named in WEM.
- **Implication:** specialised AI capabilities are not enough to secure these analyst placements. Observe.AI's new coaching capabilities remain a counterpoint to that assessment.

Two workforce deals target adjacent markets

- Thoma Bravo announced a strategic growth investment in Tanda, which serves roughly 8,000 shift-based businesses. Terms were undisclosed; Jake Phillpot remains chief executive.
- Tanda describes this as its first outside capital in fourteen years.
- Thoma Bravo already owns Verint, Calabrio and Cogito. Its Tanda announcement makes no reference to combining them.
- Main Capital Partners took a majority stake in Orgvue from One Peak Partners. The deal was announced this week but closed in August.

- Orgvue focuses on strategic workforce planning and organisation design. Both deals sit outside contact-centre workforce management.

Wonderful combines software with substantial services

- Wonderful reportedly reached roughly \$70 million revenue run-rate from near zero in a year.
- Around 400 of its 650 staff work inside customer organisations. Its reported gross margin is about 52%.
- **Implication:** revenue growth in this category can depend on substantial service delivery, rather than software alone.

Other product and market developments

- **Sierra:** released multimodal agents combining voice, text and visuals, plus hyper- τ -bench, which evaluates models' ability to build agents. Neither announcement includes commercial or performance figures.
- **Cresta:** signed Marshawn Lynch as a spokesperson and launched advertising. No contract value or media budget was disclosed.
- **Zoom:** calls its goal "conversation to completion," moving beyond containing a contact to finishing the customer's task. The product-lead interview was a paid media partnership.
- **Aragon:** launched an Intelligent Communications Experience category, forecasting \$251.83 billion by 2031 in a paid press release endorsed by Intermedia, Mitel, RingCentral and Vonage.

California's workplace-AI bills await the Governor

All three bills have passed the legislature and reached the Governor. None is signed or vetoed. They become law unless the Governor vetoes them by 30 September.

- **AB 1883:** would prohibit employers from using AI surveillance tools to recognise or infer employees' emotions, or collect neural data.
- Its enrolled text has no wellness or stress-monitoring exception. The safety provision does not permit the prohibited emotion-recognition use.
- Neural data means measurements of nervous-system activity, excluding inferences from non-neural information. Penalties reach \$500 per violation, enforced by the Labor Commissioner or public prosecutors.
- **SB 947:** would prohibit sole reliance on automated systems for discipline or termination, with an operative date of 1 July 2027 if enacted.
- Employers primarily relying on automated output must have a person corroborate it. Uncorroborated, inaccurate, incomplete or misleading output cannot be used.
- Once automated-system use is shown, the employer must demonstrate compliance or that it did not primarily rely on the output.

- The enrolled bill uses public enforcement. It does not contain a private right of action or a separate emotion-prediction ban.
- **SB 951:** would require mass-layoff notices to identify jobs substantially displaced by AI or automation, their functions and locations, and the type of system involved.
- Notices would carry “This notice is for a technology displacement.” The state would publish a quarterly summary.

Other regulatory developments

- **Connecticut:** AI-contribution disclosure for qualifying mass layoffs takes effect on 1 October. No prescribed form or guidance has surfaced.
- **Colorado:** revised automated-decision-making rules are due by 23 September. Comments and the hearing are scheduled for 26 October; final rules take effect on 1 January 2027.
- **United Kingdom:** consultation on workplace monitoring closes on 30 September.
- **European Union:** no new workplace-emotion-AI enforcement action surfaced in the covered official sources. National activity may not be visible in English-language reporting.
- Gartner lists emotion AI among future-of-work technologies, while California’s proposed restrictions and existing EU workplace prohibitions point employers toward tighter limits.

Gartner expects some AI-driven layoffs to reverse

- Gartner forecasts that 30% of employees laid off because AI replaced them will need rehiring by 2029, often at higher cost.
- Analyst Emily Potosky expects this to be especially pronounced in customer service, where work remains and future AI prices are uncertain.
- Gartner reports median 2025 AI spending of almost \$6 million among service and support organisations.
- CX Dive reports Gartner’s use-case split: roughly 25% negative returns, 25% positive and 42% unclear value. The underlying study’s date is unverified.
- **Implication:** reducing headcount before proving service capacity and economics can create rehiring costs. This is Gartner’s forecast, not a measured reversal rate.

Predictions: where the evidence stands

Assessments combine recent developments with earlier evidence.

Our assessment of the annual report’s eighteen predictions: eleven supported, three weakened, two unchanged, and two still untested or not triggered.

Shared platforms and pricing

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
One shared human/AI engine	Strong support	Genesys Navigator and Orchestrator are not yet generally available.
Repricing and seat displacement	Supported, qualified	Pricing models coexist; Five9 still reports human-seat growth.
Disproof test: return to seat pricing	Not triggered	No reported reversal among tracked vendors; moves to minutes or credits would escape this H1 2027 test.

Quality and analytics

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
AI changes quality teams' work	Strong support	Observe.AI keeps supervisors approving coaching plans.
Specialists defend through depth	Weakened	ISG placements favour platforms; Observe.AI still adds specialised capabilities.
The independent middle consolidates	Unchanged	Tanda and Orgvue deals concern adjacent markets.

Workforce management

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Autonomous intraday scheduling	Weakened	Available examples retain human decisions or review.
Verint/Calabrio product integration	Unchanged	A unified product remains unproven, five and a half months after their joint event.
Planning combines people and AI	Strong support	Five9 contracts and shared routing support a blended planning model.

Performance and engagement

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Emotion-AI restrictions constrain use	Still untested	California bills await the Governor; no new EU enforcement surfaced.
Coaching competes on outcomes	Supported, qualified	Reported outcomes remain vendor-supplied or vendor-staged.
Simulation protects independents	Weakened	No new substantive support for the prediction.

Agent assistance

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Assist coordinates a shared engine	Strong support	Microsoft, Genesys and Five9 show parts of this model.
Automated summaries drive adoption	Strong support	Customer reports support usefulness; people still review sensitive summaries.
Human assist stays in seat prices	Supported, qualified	Zendesk plans usage charges for voice translation.

Autonomous customer experience

Prediction	Assessment	Key qualification
Outcome pricing replaces seats	Supported where published	Three of five tracked vendors publish no list; published pages are undated.
Who acts determines the charging model	Strong support	Microsoft's listed human tools and autonomous agents use different charging models.
Completion replaces deflection	Supported in positioning	Containment remains common; no audited fulfilment rate supports a market-wide shift.

- **Pricing qualification:** outcome models exist, but the original claim's requirement for dated price pages does not hold for the pages available.
- **Competition qualification:** specialist depth looks less defensible in the ISG rankings, although Observe.AI's new capabilities show continuing product development.

What to watch next

- **Salesforce:** how Fin and Agentforce pricing develop under one owner.
- **California:** action on AB 1883, SB 947 and SB 951 before 30 September.
- **Genesys:** Navigator general availability in the quarter beginning 1 November; Orchestrator in the quarter beginning 1 February.
- **Tanda and Orgvue:** whether either adjacent workforce investment develops a contact-centre connection.
- **Listen Labs:** whether reported Salesforce talks produce an agreement.
- **Lorikeet and Wonderful:** whether resolution-based pricing and service-heavy delivery prove durable business models.

Sources

Detailed citations

Company and official sources

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Reporting and transcripts

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